

Research Project Description

Conflict, Gender and Labour Markets

Submitted in support of a research stay at the
Universitat Rovira i Virgili (URV)
Department of Economics, Faculty of Economics and Business

Research team

Dr. César Luis Garro Marín
Principal Investigator

Dr. Masyhur Hilmy
Co-Investigator
University of New South Wales
Australia

Abstract

Exposure to violence has well-documented damaging effects, yet we still know little about how these impacts may differ for men and women. Understanding these gender-specific effects is crucial for designing well-targeted policies that address these harms effectively. In this project, we study how exposure to violence affects the work and family choices of men and women and their beliefs about gender roles using data from Mexico and Colombia. To identify the effects of exposure, we take advantage of rich administrative and survey data and use a Difference-in-Difference strategy that exploits within-country differences in exposure, driven by both Mexico's large increase and Colombia's decline in violence during the 2000s and early 2010s. Besides uncovering potential gender-specific responses to violence, the contrast between the two settings will allow us to study response differences to increases and declines in violence.

Dr. César Luis Garro Marín
Visiting researcher

Dr. María Llop Llop
Catedrática y Directora
Departamento de Economía
Universitat Rovira i Virgili

1. Motivation and Proposal

Latin America is home to more than 30% of the world’s murders despite having less than 10% of the world’s population (Jaitman and Machin, 2016). Despite the well-documented negative effects of violence on labour markets, health, and other outcomes, we still know very little about whether and how these impacts differ for men and women, and how they affect intra-household decision making. Understanding this potential gender heterogeneity is crucial for designing well-targeted policy responses that address these harms effectively.

In this project, we study how exposure to violence affects the work and family decisions of both men and women, as well as their beliefs about gender roles, using data from Mexico and Colombia. We take advantage of both time and within-country geographic variation in violence exposure driven by sharp changes in conflict in these two countries during the 2000s. Between 2007 and 2011, Mexico experienced a sharp increase in drug-related conflict, with the homicide rate rising by 287%, from 8.5 to 24.4 homicides per 100,000 people (Velásquez, 2020); over the same decade, Colombia’s homicide rate fell sharply, from about 70 to under 35 homicides per 100,000 people. In Mexico, detailed administrative and survey data allow us to study beliefs, work, and family responses to the post-2007 increase in drug-related violence; in Colombia, census and survey data allow us to study responses to the post-2000 decline in civil war violence. Studying both settings jointly lets us examine response heterogeneity to increases and declines in violence within the same research design.

Why would responses to violence differ between men and women? Evidence suggests that men and women have different perceptions of the level of safety (Gustafsson, 1998; Huddy, Feldman, Taber, and Lahav, 2005). Additionally, there is evidence that the risk of violence affects women’s education and work choices (Borker, 2018). At the same time, because men are the primary participants in armed conflict and crime, increases in violence are often a male-biased shock that could help reinforce more traditional gender roles (Dincecco, Fenske, Gupta, and Menon, 2024). Gender-specific responses can also modify bargaining power within the household and thus affect intra-household relationships.

This project makes three main contributions. First, it provides new evidence on the relationship between gender-role beliefs and conflict. Previous work on culture and gender uses historical episodes or ancient technological innovations to show the long-term impact of gender-biased shocks on current gender inequality and beliefs about gender roles (Alesina, Giuliano, and Nunn, 2013; Dincecco, Fenske, Gupta, and Menon, 2024; Ramos-Toro, 2019), but we know comparatively little about the shorter-run responsiveness of these beliefs to conflict; this project contributes by taking advantage of recent conflict shocks and rich data on gender outcomes from two large developing countries.

Second, by focusing on the effects of violence on gender inequality, we contribute

to the large literature on the impact of violence and conflict, which has documented negative effects on work, education, trust, and political attitudes (Akresh, Lucchetti, and Thirumurthy, 2012; Brown, Montalva, Thomas, and Velásquez, 2019; Dube and Naidu, 2015; Velásquez, 2020), but has offered little evidence on whether these effects differ by gender or extend to family formation and intra-household relationships.

Third, by studying the effects of both an increase and a decline in violence, we provide evidence on the heterogeneity of responses to different types of shocks: conflict research has mostly studied responses to episodes of increased violence (Brown, Montalva, Thomas, and Velásquez, 2019; Brown and Velásquez, 2017; Dube and Vargas, 2013; Velásquez, 2020), while responses to declines in violence, which can be more informative of the effects of successful conflict abatement, remain comparatively underexplored.

2. Data

We will use and link multiple data sources on (i) violence, (ii) household dynamics, (iii) demographics and employment, and (iv) income and expenditure, for both Mexico and Colombia.

For Mexico, violence exposure is measured using the **Mexican Death Registry** (*Registro Administrativo de Defunciones*), an administrative registry of natural and violent deaths covering all of Mexico, 2001–2024. Household dynamics – including bargaining, fertility, and intimate partner violence – are captured through the **ENDIREH** (National Survey of Household Relationship Dynamics, 2003–2021), the **ENADID** (National Survey of Demographic Dynamics, 1997–2018), and administrative **Marriage and Divorce Registries** covering all of Mexico, 1995–2024. Demographics and employment outcomes come from the **ENOE/ENE** (National Survey of Employment and Occupation, 1995–2024) and **IPUMS International** samples of the Mexican Decennial Censuses and Intercensal Surveys, 1990–2020. Income and expenditure data come from the **ENIGH** (National Survey of Household Income and Expenditure, 1996–2024). All of these datasets are publicly available.

Colombian individual-level demographic and labour market data will come from the 1993, 2005, and 2018 National Population Censuses, the 2001–2005 National Household Survey, and the 2006–2018 Integrated Household Survey. Additionally, data on safety and crime will come from all waves of the National Safety Survey and national crime statistics. All these datasets are publicly available.

3. Methodology

To estimate the effects of changes in violence exposure across genders, we exploit geographic variation in the exposure to violence induced by the large changes in violence

in the 2000s in Mexico and Colombia. Changes in government policy in both countries during this decade induced large changes in the overall level of violence. However, due to the geographic concentration of conflict activity, there was substantial variation in the changes in violence experienced across municipalities (Velásquez, 2020).

We use a Difference-in-Differences strategy that exploits this geographic heterogeneity in changes in violence. This strategy compares changes in the outcomes of interest – beliefs, gender-specific labour market outcomes, household dynamics, and related measures – in municipalities with large changes in violence exposure versus those with small changes. We will measure changes in the level of violence using changes in the municipality-level homicide rate, and will be interested in effects across gender in outcomes such as labour supply, types of jobs held, fertility, time allocation within the household, and beliefs about gender roles, among others.

There are two main potential limitations to this approach. First, changes in violence could be correlated with other unobserved changes across municipalities. Second, there are known pitfalls in interpreting Difference-in-Differences estimates with continuous treatments such as ours (Roth, Sant’Anna, Bilinski, and Poe, 2023).

We address these limitations by examining the robustness of our results to alternative identification strategies, incorporating the recommendations of the recent Difference-in-Differences literature. Where appropriate, we also use an approach similar to Dell (2007), who exploits changes in violence in Mexico driven by close municipal elections in which the winning mayor aligned with the government’s anti-drug policy.

4. Research team

- **Dr. César Luis Garro Marín** (Principal Investigator) – School of Economics, University of Edinburgh. PhD in Economics, Boston University (2023). Leads the research design, data linkage, and empirical analysis, and will carry out this work while in residence at the Department of Economics of the URV.
- **Dr. Masyhur Hilmy** (Co-Investigator) – School of Economics, UNSW Business School, University of New South Wales. PhD in Economics (2023). Contributes to the identification strategy, the Colombia data work, and the drafting and revision of the paper.
- **Research assistant (to be hired)** – based in Colombia, expected to hold or be close to completing a Bachelor’s degree in Economics with experience in Stata, R, or Python. Assists with data collection, cleaning, and preliminary analysis for both the Mexican and Colombian data sources, under the supervision of the Principal Investigator.

- **Dr. María Llop Llop** (Host researcher) – Departamento de Economía, Facultad de Economía y Empresa, URV. Supervises and hosts the visiting researcher during the stay.

The team communicates through regular online meetings to discuss progress and next steps, complemented by a shared channel for time-sensitive queries.

5. Budget

The project is funded by a Small Research Grant from the British Academy/Leverhulme Trust (SRG 2025 Round, reference SRG25\252295), awarded to Dr. Garro Marín for a total of €6,146¹ covering the period October 2026–October 2027.

Budget item	Amount (EUR)
Research/clerical assistance	€3,253
Consumables	€216
Conference participation	€2,677
Total	€6,146

Table 1: Summary of the project budget.

Research/clerical assistance covers approximately six months of part-time work (0.75 FTE) for a Colombia-based research assistant, including base salary, mandatory employer contributions, and incidental research costs.

Consumables covers a one-year single-user Stata/SE licence.

Conference participation covers registration fees, accommodation, and airfares for presenting the project’s results at national and international academic conferences.

This grant funds the project’s data work, research assistance, and dissemination activities as a whole. The stay at the URV does not require additional funding from the host institution; the visiting researcher’s costs during the stay are covered by his own resources and by the British Academy/Leverhulme grant referenced above.

6. Work plan and tasks to be carried out by the researcher

The project timetable is organised into four phases. During the stay at the URV, the Principal Investigator will carry out the tasks corresponding to the phase(s) of the project overlapping with the visit, working from the Department of Economics.

¹Amounts converted from the grant’s original GBP allocation (£5,298) at an approximate exchange rate of £1 = €1.16.

Phase 1 – Data access and cleaning, recruitment of the research assistant (October–November 2026). Collection, cleaning, and harmonisation of the publicly available Mexican and Colombian datasets on labour market outcomes, gender attitudes, household dynamics, and crime and safety, and linkage of these sources at the municipality level. In parallel, recruitment of the Colombia-based research assistant, who will support coding, data cleaning, and the construction of tables and figures throughout Phases 2 and 3.

Phase 2 – Main analysis, initial results, and preliminary draft (December 2026–January 2027). Implementation of the Difference-in-Differences empirical strategy, estimation of the effects of changes in violence exposure across genders, and drafting of a preliminary version of the paper summarising the initial results, to be used for conference submissions.

Phase 3 – Robustness checks and dissemination of results (February–September 2027). Assessment of the robustness of the estimates using alternative identification strategies, addressing potential threats to identification such as correlated unobserved changes across municipalities and known pitfalls of Difference-in-Differences designs with continuous treatment. Concurrently, submission and presentation of results in internal seminars and at national and international academic conferences.

Phase 4 – Drafting of the research paper (October 2027). Incorporation of feedback received during Phase 3 into a version of the paper ready for submission to academic journals, together with a non-technical summary for dissemination to non-academic audiences.

The specific tasks to be developed by the visiting researcher at the URV include: designing and implementing the empirical strategy; supervising the data cleaning and construction of the analysis datasets; producing and interpreting the empirical results; drafting sections of the research paper; and participating in seminars and discussions with members of the Department of Economics relevant to the project.

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